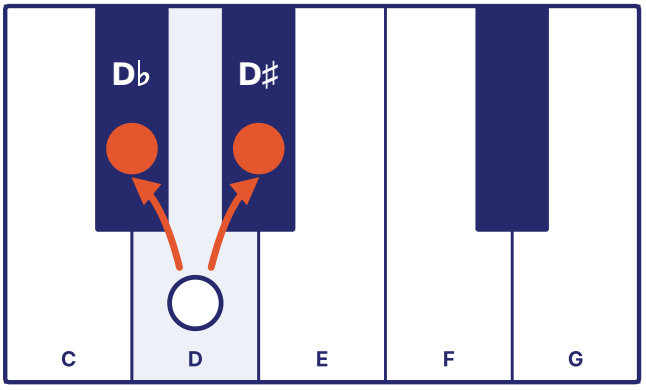
PART I · PITCH · 5

Sharps, flats and naturals

A sign in front of a note moves it to the very next key. **Sharp**: one key to the **right**. **Flat**: one key to the **left**. Usually that next key is black, which is how the black keys get their names.

THE SECRET

Sharp: the very next key to the right. Flat: the very next key to the left.

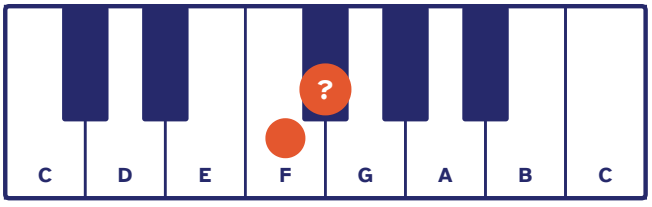


♯ one key right · ♭ one key left

SIGN	NAME	WHAT IT DOES	FIRST MET
♯	sharp	one key to the right (a semitone higher)	Level 0
♭	flat	one key to the left (a semitone lower)	Level 0
♮	natural	cancels a sharp or flat: back to the white key	Level ½

EXAMPLE 1

Find F♯



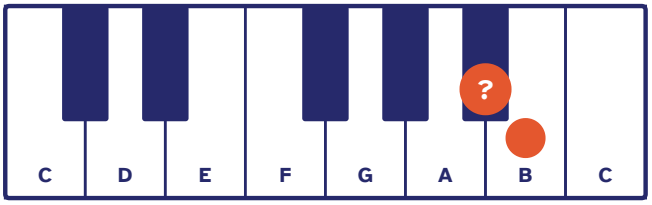
1. **Find F** (the red dot): just left of the three black keys.
2. **Sharp means right:** move to the very next key.
3. **Is it black or white?** Put your finger on it.

The **?** is **F♯**: the first black key of the group of three.

PART I · PITCH · 5 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Find B♭
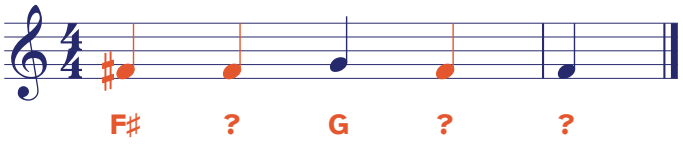


1. **Find B** (the red dot): just right of the three black keys.
2. **Flat means left:** move to the very next key.
3. **Which black key is it?**

The **?** is **B♭**: the top black key of the group of three.

EXAMPLE 3

How long does the sharp last?

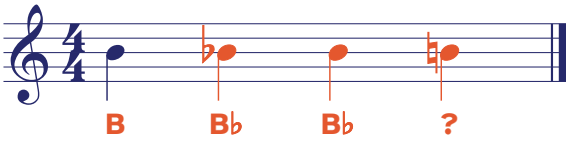


1. **The first note** has a sharp: F♯.
2. **Later in the same bar** there is no sign. Is it still sharp?
3. **After the bar line**: is it still sharp?

Still **F♯** until the bar line; after it, plain **F** again. A sign lasts **to the end of its bar**.

EXAMPLE 4

A natural cancels the flat
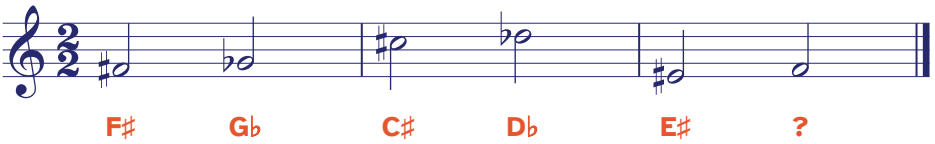


1. **B**: the white key.
2. **B♭**: one key left, and it stays flat for the rest of the bar.
3. **The last note** has a natural sign: what does it do?

The natural **cancels** the flat: back to the white key B, until the bar line.

PART I · PITCH · 5 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 5

One key, two names



1 **The first bar:** F♯, then G♭. Find both on the keyboard.

2 **Are they different keys?**

3 **The last bar:** E♯. Which key is one right of E?

F♯ and G♭ are the **same black key**; E♯ is the white key **F**. Same sound, different names: **enharmonic**.

GAME

Which key is it?
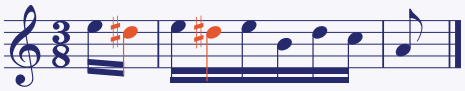
1	2	3	4
C♯	E♭	B♯	F♭

Sharp: one key to the right. Flat: one key to the left. Which key do you press?

Answer: 1 the black key right of C · 2 the black key left of E · 3 the white key C · 4 the white key E.

YOU KNOW THIS

Für Elise (Beethoven)



E, D♯, E, D♯: the very next key down and back. The sharp is written again in the new bar, because the bar line wiped it out.

Try it. Play E and D♯ back and forth: the black key just left of E.

THINK OF IT A sharp or flat is a sticky note on one line of the staff: it stays stuck until the bar line, then it falls off.

TRAP

× Carrying a sharp or flat past the bar line: after it, the note is plain again.

SEE ALSO
Keys and key signatures p. 75

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Pitch 3 · Online: Library › Signs